How Economists Discuss Central Bank Digital Currencies

Themes, Tone and Stance, 2014–2026

Adriel Mazere*

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Abstract

Keywords:
JEL codes:

1 Introduction

2 Related literature

2.1 Central bank digital currencies

2.2 What the field builds on

2.3 Bibliometric and text-as-data studies of CBDCs

Within our corpus, we observe 77 titles that announce a literature, systematic or bibliometric review of CBDCs, published between 2019 and 2026. When comparing the five most recent bibliometric studies with ours, we found three shared main limits. First, their data come from one or two databases,Scopus and/or Web of Science, and are mostly journal papers written in English. Working papers, central-bank speeches and press are therefore mostly absent from their analysis, so that their sample is very limited compared to ours: a few hundred documents compared to 17,709. In addition, they build their analysis with standard tools that mainly describe what is studied, but not why. Finally, their classifications are never checked against a reading of the texts themselves.

Our study addresses these three limits. Our corpus is much larger, with papers coming from five databases, speeches and press, in different languages. We ask not only what is written but also who writes it, why, how and when.

3 Data

3.1 Sources and collection

3.2 De-duplication and enrichment

3.3 Relevance: is CBDC the theme?

3.4 Who counts as an economist

3.5 Descriptive statistics

*M2 – Private crypto.

4 Who writes

4.1 Method: co-citation, co-authorship, bibliometric laws and distinctive vocabulary

4.2 Findings

5 What is written

5.1 Method: thematic map, topic model and covariate-adjusted shares

5.2 Findings

6 How economists discuss CBDCs: tone and stance

6.1 Method: tone (FinBERT) and stance (reading and a local language model)

6.2 Findings

6.3 Do policy events move the tone?

7 Why: stated motivations

7.1 Method: a validated codebook

7.2 Findings

8 When: the policy environment

8.1 Method: bursts, event study with placebo dates, difference-in-differences

8.2 Findings

9 The discussion and its environment

9.1 Period by period

9.2 What can and cannot be said about causes

10 Robustness

11 Discussion

11.1 Limitations

12 Conclusion

Data and code availability

A Search vocabulary

B Harvesting algorithms

C Validation samples and coding guide

D Additional tables and figures